

Gaining Local Legitimacy in Stabilization Operations: The Spanish Peacekeepers Case in Lebanon-UNIFIL II

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This article analyses the role of peacekeeping in enhancing a host nation's local legitimacy within its population, focusing on the mission actions from a bottom-up perspective. This research, which used a micro-approach with the Spanish contingent case study in UNIFIL II, involved two field studies carried out between 2010 and 2016 in Lebanon with interviews and focus groups with Spanish military personnel of this UN mission and local Lebanese actors. The results show how the implementation of both material actions —the provision of public goods and security— and non-material actions —respect and an in-depth knowledge about the local context—, performed by Spanish peacekeepers towards local actors, helped to improve the local legitimacy and reconciled the goals of the mission with the interests of Lebanese society and state.

Keywords: legitimacy; peacekeeping; UNIFIL; Lebanon; non-material actions; Spain; Spanish Armed Forces.

Introduction

The legitimacy of peacekeeping military operations has been traditionally linked to the host-nation consenting to the deployment of a mission mandate that has been legitimately agreed.¹ Thus, international and national legitimacy had been ubiquitous, but local legitimacy had not always considered; even scientific literature has largely neglected the local practices within international peacebuilding operations.² It was only after the failed state-building operations in Iraq and Afghanistan in the first decade of the twenty-first century when the 'local turn' was broadly adopted and gradually influenced the modus operandi of international missions.³ Since then, an increasing number of documents published by the United Nations as well as other international agencies and organizations, and the academic community have specifically focused on this micro-level 'perspective of the local'⁴ and the local legitimacy as a resource to

improve the relations among locals and internationals.

Giving the importance of understanding the local for the success of the peacekeeping missions, the concept of legitimacy is progressively relevant in scientific research about peace and stabilisation operations. In the last two decades, these operations have entailed a range of peacekeeping and peacebuilding activities related to supporting the authority, capacity, capability, and legitimacy of the host state.⁵ The provision of public services — such as humanitarian aid, cultural projects, infrastructure reconstruction, medical care, security sector reform, security, elections and gender advice— by armed forces (among other international actors) have all been aimed at helping the state to recover lost ground and regain the confidence of local populations. Furthermore, understanding the beliefs and practices of local populations —which are not always in line with liberal Western values— is a complementary axis in the research about local legitimacy.⁶ Therefore, local communities have become active, central actors in international missions as their acceptance of the international mission has become required.⁷

In this respect, this work concentrates on the subnational area, particularly on civil communities, as well as political and religious elites, shedding light on practices and contexts for the development of local legitimacy under the umbrella of UN stabilisation operations. It focuses on the daily events and activities carried out by peacebuilders to improve interactions with the environment.⁸ Concretely, its research question concerns whether the material and non-material actions induced by the peacekeepers within the expanded United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL II) mission have helped to enhance the legitimacy of the Lebanese state from the local level. While Lebanon is not a failed state, it faces numerous problems: a severe economic and social crisis, and a lack of territorial control in the south the country, coping with a strong Hezbollah

presence and the aftermath of the 2006 war between Israel and the Shi'a militia.

Our aim is to explain how local legitimacy can be strengthened through the performance of peacekeepers, using a concrete case study for which we have data. Indeed, the study employs a qualitative in-depth research based on 85 interviews and two focus groups with both local actors and Spanish military personnel who were part of the UNIFIL II contingent. It presents a bottom-up case that can be used to examine micro-level dynamics and to highlight the importance of local activities and the actions of international actors.⁹ Those actions, framed within the context of UNIFIL's mission, not only facilitate the application of results to other international missions, but also yield valuable insights for future qualitative or comparative analyses.

The article is organised as follows. It first provides a theoretical framework, discussing the most relevant research to show how this work contributes to previous analyses. The next section, which discusses the methodology of the study, is followed by an analysis of the Lebanese case study to explain how local legitimacy for the Lebanese state can be gained through specific material and non-material actions.

Legitimacy in peace operations: Tangible and ideational issues to gain local legitimacy

The concept of legitimacy, in the Weberian sense, is based on the non-coercive consent of citizens to a form of domination that has the ability to create valid institutions. This idea is more difficult when applied to peacekeeping operations, where the 'social contract' is made with the host nation, and not with the local population,¹⁰ but which must be included in the process of reconstruction and state-building in order to gain legitimacy at the local level. The tension between top-down and bottom-up approaches is evident among the different forms of legitimacy and its principles.¹¹ From this

perspective, the transactional nature of legitimacy as consent in state-citizen relations can be appreciated.¹² Local communities, in turn, must develop a ‘sense of obligation or willingness to obey’ the authority of a governance actor, or governance institution.¹³ Thus, gaining local legitimacy requires a bottom-up perspective.

For a variety of reasons (economic crises, conflicts, non-recognition of beliefs and practices, etc.), states are often not able to meet the needs of their own populations, which means that the implementation of their decisions is not perceived as legitimate by its citizens. However, a state may be supported by external actors that can contribute to its governance and help to gain the trust of the local population, as is the case with international peace operations. Termed ‘empirical legitimacy’ by Thomas Risse and Eric Stollenwerk, this ‘obligation or willingness’ is based on the performance of a particular peacekeeping mission.¹⁴

According to Angstrom, a peacekeeping operation , ‘changes and conditions a new strategic environment for the local actors [...] Through its greater economic and coercive powers, [it] can create expectations of increased stability and lend its coercive powers to the home-grown Leviathan in the making’.¹⁵ The challenge facing the external force is to work on behalf of development at the local level; which, in turn, would foster stability.¹⁶ If the peacekeepers successfully provide services, replacing the weaknesses of the state, the host nation's institutions could potentially gain legitimacy.¹⁷

At any rate, legitimacy involves two levels: international framework and local context. The first concerns the international mission itself, including the content of its mandate and a valid procedure for its approval by the United Nations to warrant its deployment. For UNIFIL II, its mandate enjoyed broad international support (i.e., international legitimacy) and national legitimacy since the United Nations Security Council Resolution 1701 was unanimously adopted on august 12, 2006.

The second level takes shape amid the scenario in which the mission is deployed. Having an international mandate does not mean that the entire local community will view the intervention as legitimate. Perceived social and cultural distance between the contingent's country and the host nation (language, religion, degree of economic development, geographical origin of the troops, etc.) can negatively affect the task entrusted to the peacekeepers: the greater the difference, the more complicate it can be to obtain legitimacy in the local context and, therefore, to accomplish effectively the established mission goal.¹⁸

In Lebanon, the society in which the mission is deployed has profound socio-cultural differences that are the result of long-standing conflicts.¹⁹ This means that the 'local' population is highly fragmented, consisting in eighteen Christians and Muslims historical communities. Moreover, there are multiple actors vying for legitimacy among the population, including the Lebanese state, with the support of the peacekeeping mission on one side, and Hezbollah.²⁰ In fact, facilitating access to social welfare has been, for instance, positively associated with support and partisanship in Hezbollah.²¹

As in other developing countries and post-conflict settings, social relations between citizens in Lebanon may be considered more important than the potential connection between the state and its citizens through a social contract.²² The complex situation in Lebanon has led some studies to identify up to 'seven sources of legitimacy claimed by external actors for their presence and activities in Lebanon: international legal framework; delivery and technical skill; in-country orientation; track record; technocratic standards; peer legitimacy; and external legitimacy'.²³

In our work, we focus on two sources of legitimacy: material factors (related with delivery and technical skills) and ideational actions (related to in-country orientation), that allow for the building and gaining of legitimacy to extend the authority

of the state. Peacekeepers must convince the host nation of the legitimacy of their authority,²⁴ but authority can only be maintained with the acceptance and consent of the local population.²⁵ In this case, the mission must serve the host-state and cannot have its own legitimacy against the state. The only available instrument is to satisfy the needs of the population and begin to build structures and institutions that meet local demands while respecting the culture and ways of life of the host state.

Tangible and ideational issues to gain local legitimacy

There are several both tangible and ideational issues that bolster the acquisition of legitimacy. In particular, the locals need to perceive security and some stimulus or inducement through material benefits, delivery of public goods in the ancillary activities related to development projects and financial contribution to the economy,²⁶ as well as respect for their culture,²⁷ protocols and local necessities²⁸ which requires bearing existing discourses in mind. In return, the mission's international forces establish security and gain recognition for their work in supporting peacebuilding efforts. These tangible issues are what, in fact, Tschunkert and McGinty call "delivery and technical skills" as a second source of legitimacy and the ideational one, what they define as "in-country orientation".²⁹

The provision of basic services and security is related to the strength of the state,³⁰ as the most visible form of the social contract established between the parties. There is a correlation between the provision of public services and the enhancement of legitimacy, although this need not always be linear.³¹ In this regard, people's expectation of service delivery in a context of peacebuilding operations is crucial to gaining legitimacy.³² The actions related to specific projects seek to compensate for the lack of public policies in a weak state under construction,³³ or the impossibility of

developing them due to the conflict situation. With their functions, external actors imitate or fill important gaps in traditional state duties.³⁴

Delivering public services involves transactions that create social networks of trust and co-operation, as well as power relations.³⁵ This necessarily involves providing the mission with knowledge of the local culture and the discourses that articulate its world view. Therefore, the essential element which connects the ideational, or non-material with the tangible or material is knowledge of the context, of the local way of life and culture that is configured through the society's mythical and rational discourses. This helps to establish priorities when using resources.³⁶

Here the most complex and confusing point explored in scholarly works to date is whether peacekeeping operations and peacekeepers can, at some point, be perceived as being legitimate in the ideational sense;³⁷ this produces a strategy that is favourable to the mission, by establishing the essential elements at the local level. Identifying threats and prioritising resources can, to a large extent, require an in-depth understanding of the cultural context and the control of the discourses or narratives, which involves winning the battle of perceptions. Thus, human interaction and a continuous dialogue with local populations are fundamental to overcome negative beliefs and perceptions.

Therefore, the legitimacy of the international mission is a source of power because it drives local actors to comply and co-operate. The interaction of the mission with local elites is; as a consequence, a key issue that also affects legitimacy balances.³⁸ Subnational elites and locals in general are no longer seen as something static; rather, a dynamic game is played in terms of relationships, activities, and networks in a given context.³⁹ In this sense, the power relations constructed are different: local populations and subnational elites can be empowered by becoming 'potential saviours' for

peacebuilding operations.⁴⁰ This perspective reinforces the assumption that peacebuilding operations must move from a traditional state-centric approach to one of strengthening social cohesion and improving state-society relations.⁴¹

Consequently, the local population can recognise their leaders in the subnational elites, who in turn join some players or others.⁴² A process that could be triggered by the difference in power and resources between local communities, or members of local communities.⁴³ The problems arise when the subnational elites seek to reinforce their legitimacy vis-à-vis their community by obtaining benefits from the peacekeeping mission. In these contexts, it is common for local leaders to retain certain levels of legitimacy and status,⁴⁴ in an attempt to obtain both recognition and the resources of the international mission and actors.⁴⁵ For these relationships to be valid, it is necessary for the force to have the necessary knowledge of the context for negotiation purposes and to avoid being manipulated by the local actors. This knowledge includes the use of narratives or discourses, whether mythical or rational.⁴⁶

While the mission mandate aims to establish a rule of law, subnational elites, especially in highly culturally diverse settings, tend to use mythical discourses in which the rules for obtaining authority are based on traditions, or customs that confer legitimacy on the leaders of the communities. On the contrary, a rational discourse seeks to justify the legitimacy of subnational elites through a negotiation that produces a national social contract, which will be the source of legitimacy for the state. Therefore, the mission must be efficient and effective in the implementation of the procedures within its mandate. To do so, it needs to strike a balance between respecting the ways of life and culture in the specific context and the rule of law. It must also be effective by trying to increase the mission's probability of success.

These two objectives can only be met through a profound knowledge of the context and how the subnational elites may use the various discourses as an element of negotiation. This understanding, moreover, must be taken into consideration at the strategic level of the mission, and instruments need to be put in place to secure that knowledge at the tactical level. However, offering assistance to subnational elites who position themselves by using a mythical discourse may unwittingly facilitate actions that foster authoritarianism.⁴⁷ When the international community establishes the terms of a mission's mandate, it gives priority to common values and respect for national sovereignty. If the deployment of the mission ignores efficiency in terms of establishing valid procedures and prioritises effectiveness, ending hostilities at any cost, the mission will have failed to uphold its values.

A mission may choose to benefit the players who try to impose a mythical discourse with the acquiescence of the international community, but this reduces the chances that the construction of a state will be determined by the rule of law. Likewise, the respect for human rights in general and the rights of ethnic, cultural or linguistic minorities are values upheld by the international community and recognised by the United Nations: the source of the mission's legitimacy. If the resulting state is not able to guarantee security, stability, and peace, it will lose the support of the population. Nonetheless, it should be considered that these 'universal' values may encounter frictions vis-à-vis social practices, traditions and cultural features of the host society. As a consequence, this normative approach may require greater flexibility in the norms and values the missions implicitly or explicitly promote.⁴⁸

Subnational elites are interested in normalising and institutionalising relations with peacekeepers, as this will increase their own legitimacy. Accordingly, these elites prioritise resources, taking the ability to establish public policies away from the

international mission and, in the case at hand, from the Lebanese state. For the mission to gain legitimacy, it needs to obtain power by means of two intangible assets: authority and security. The ultimate goal is to produce a legitimacy monopoly controlled by the state, which will enter into a process of construction, stabilisation, and peacekeeping, an objective that requires an unanimously accepted national social contract.

Methodology

The relevance of the case study also lies in the fact that, after the 2006 Lebanon War, UNIFIL II was tasked, in addition to the original mandate—dating back to 1978—to strengthen the sovereignty and authority of the Lebanese state, with several commitments: monitoring the cessation of hostilities between Hezbollah and Israel; accompanying and assisting the Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) throughout the southern part of the country and along the border between Israel and Lebanon (the so-called ‘Blue Line’), which is the key objective of the mission;⁴⁹ and ensuring humanitarian access to civilian populations and the voluntary and safe return of displaced persons. To meet these objectives, UNIFIL II needed to develop a series of low-profile tasks that support the core work of the mandate.⁵⁰ Its aim is to ensure that the Lebanese state has a legitimacy monopoly throughout the territory, in order to extend its institutions.

Besides this premise, the selection of UNIFIL II was based on the following criteria, aiming to contribute novel evidence to the field practices conducted within its specific framework: (i) soft-skills and non-material actions by peacekeepers have been observed in the mission as a way to gain local trust and confidence;⁵¹ (ii) the fact that it is one of the longest and best manned missions in terms of the military personnel in the contingent and one of the most important operations in the Middle East,⁵² which also specifically seeks co-ordination with the LAF and the interaction with local

communities; (iii) Lebanon is a particularly complex case of state-building, where other actors besides the state, such as Hezbollah, enjoy political legitimacy, underlining the relevance of the case study;⁵³ (iv) to contribute some ideas in addition to ethnographic studies carried out.⁵⁴

Regarding the Spanish peacekeepers international mission in Lebanon used to answer the research question of this paper, it should be highlighted that the Spanish Armed Forces (SAF) participation has not been studied in previous research about the Lebanese crisis,⁵⁵ even though is a major contributor to the mission. Since 2012 it regularly contributes with around 650 servicemen to the force, stepping up to 700 in 2024⁵⁶ and has twice held command of the mission, Since 2022, a Spanish General leads the mission.

In addition to these reasons, the Spanish case is also interesting because Spain falls within the group of countries that most frequently utilise soft power as part of its military strategy. Spanish peacekeepers have traditionally developed efforts to conduct modes of engagement that foster ancillary measures, trying to produce higher levels of trust with the local communities; these more neutral activities help to strengthen the authority of the state and are less likely to provoke conflict.⁵⁷ This operational preference may have facilitated the implementation of the aforementioned technical skills and in-country orientation. Indeed, recent studies have explored this situation and found that some armies are more inclined to give priority to humanitarian activities and take the time to build valid relationships with local communities.⁵⁸

The data used in this study comes from two different projects that had broader research objectives around the examination of whether peacekeeping gains more local legitimacy for the host-state if the mission designs actions and services aimed at local communities.⁵⁹ The authors conducted a total of 85 interviews and two focus groups.

The sampling was non-random, with local elites being contacted through UNIFIL II Headquarters, while the Spanish Army's General Staff; and specifically the Training and Doctrine Command, served as the channel for contacting Spanish military personnel. The interview included the following blocks of topics: a) contact and collaboration with local armed forces and/or international armed forces; b) interaction with local population; c) engagement with local authorities and the nature of the relationship with them; d) interactions with local and international NGOs; and e) civil-military co-operation (CIMIC) tasks. Alternatively, the focus groups examine on-the-ground interactions among various actors, exploring mutual perceptions and relationships.

Concerning the two implemented research projects: on the one hand, between 2010 and 2011, 27 in-person semi-structured interviews were conducted in Lebanon, i.e., in Beirut, Tyre, Sidon, and the Spanish military base in southern Lebanon. The selection criteria included local political and religious leaders from the Spanish deployment area, local and international NGOs, UN civilian personnel, interpreters, and Spanish military personnel (see Table 1). Within the same research project, two focus groups were conducted in Spain,⁶⁰ with the selection criterion being Spanish peacekeepers —officers and non-commissioned officers—who had participated in UNIFIL II

On the other hand, between 2015 and 2016, we conducted in-person semi-structured interviews as part of a comparative study encompassing various missions in which Spain had engaged, including Lebanon. The interviewees comprised military officers with leadership responsibilities who had been deployed in these missions. Initially, the sample included 24 participants, but due to the 'snowball effect,' it expanded during the course of the project. The final number of interviewees reached 50, with 26 having participated in UNIFIL II.

Table 1. Field Interview Sampling in Lebanon.

Types of interviewees	No. of participants	Community, position or Military rank	Activity
Local political leader	3	Shiite/Maronite/Druze	Mayor/District governor/Mayor
Local religious leader	3	Shiite/Sunni/Maronite	Imam/Mufti/Maronite Priest
Local NGO	1	Multicultural staff	Health services
Spanish NGO	1	Section manager	Infrastructure reconstruction
International NGO	2	Section manager	Humanitarian aid
UN staff	2	Local coordinator/staff	Refugees
Spanish Military	13	Chief of Contingent/Military Officers and NCO ^a	CIMIC
Interpreter	2	Arabic-language interpreters	Interpreters for Spanish military personnel

a. Non-commissioned officer.

Own elaboration.

The cumulative duration of both interviews and focus groups exceeded 100 hours. To maintain confidentiality, participant names were withheld by mutual agreement. Manual transcription of the interviews took place, and a deliberate choice was made to conduct the analysis without automated assistance. The focal point was on thematic units, allowing for the confirmation or rejection of the theoretical premises.

Balancing material and non-material actions to promote local legitimacy

The UNIFIL II mission began in 2006 under UN Security Council Resolution 1701. The serious crisis that took place between Israel and Hezbollah resulted in the United Nations increasing the number of ‘Blue Helmets’, the UN military personnel in the field. Spanish involvement received practically unanimous support from its parliament (only two abstentions). The Spanish contingent—which at one point amounted to some 1100 troops—is responsible since 2006 until now for the Eastern multinational brigade, composed of approximately 3500 troops from 9 different nationalities. At this time, UNIFIL II has over 10,000 peacekeepers from 47 contributing nations. Seventy per cent of the activities are performed by the LAF, making this a large mission in which local actors are more willing to co-operate.⁶¹

The work done by UNIFIL II during these years was intense, particularly the efforts by the Spanish sector to surmount an attack by Hezbollah in 2007 that resulted in the deaths of six of their peacekeepers. The Spanish military, however, has been able to help by conducting different type of actions under the mission mandate. The inducement by means of material and non-material actions of the Spanish peacekeepers were decisive in establishing valid relationships with the local population, improving perceptions about this contingent from 2007 onwards.

The material actions performed by the Spanish peacekeepers

UNIFIL II is a mix of peacekeeping mission and small-scale state-building that includes peacebuilding activities.⁶² Consequently, its involvement is important in activities related to the provision of security and public goods, as this allows the peacekeepers to engage with civilians at the micro level.⁶³ The provision of security is connected to security sector reform of the LAF and advising local police. All the military personnel interviewed commented that these were their main tasks, especially in the first months of the mission when UNIFIL II was launched. Their first tasks were aimed at accompanying LAF personnel in their operations, as a way of establishing a first contact with local actors, as well as ensuring "law and order", in the words of several Spanish peacekeepers.

Moreover, the reconstruction work and reintroduction of the LAF in southern Lebanon has been paramount for institution-building and in maintaining local security, as well as serving as a symbol of national unity.⁶⁴ The LAF represents the state, the main authority in the area, and the importance of the armed forces and other state agencies implies that Hezbollah has recognised their authority. The willingness to make

the local authority explicit was always present: “in some cases, the authorities wanted to make it clear that they were in command and had many followers”.⁶⁵

Since 2006 the LAF has developed an image neutral, non-sectarian and well-equipped institution with high approval among the local population after years of Israeli occupation.⁶⁶ That increase in the LAF’s presence, image and professionalism since 2007⁶⁷ is what Ciorciari and Krasner term an ‘islands of excellence’,⁶⁸ a phenomenon that occurs when external actors are able to transfer core capacities to local institutions that can also serve as a model for other bodies.

Therefore, patrolling, the primary activity of the peacekeeping force in Lebanon, does not merely consist of providing security, but also constitutes a mechanism to demonstrate the presence of the state and bolster its legitimacy, while strengthening relations between peacekeepers and members of the LAF: “we did reconnaissance missions [with LAF military], patrolling around towns...”⁶⁹. During these 17 years, Spanish peacekeepers conducted more than 200,000 patrols –and more than 400 explosive disposal missions—⁷⁰. Foot patrol, e.g.: on the border with Israel, provided many opportunities for interaction with LAF and local actors, as reflected in the interviews. Furthermore, when women were involved in patrolling, as in the case of the UNIFIL II mission, there was even greater proximity to the local female population.

Inducement through public goods, on the other hand, include numerous humanitarian aid (medical and veterinarian assistance) and local development projects, from general infrastructure improvement (roads and bridges), energy supply, to agricultural and livestock development.⁷¹ Secondly, when the provision of public goods is involved, the projects conducted by the UN help to promote the local economy. The various CIMIC contingents in the mission identify and support small development projects and different participation strategies. The subnational elites will act with

greater or lesser confidence depending on how they perceive the outcomes. Therefore, CIMIC work has become the most important focus of activity when both subnational elites and the local population form the mission's centre of gravity. As observed by Daniel and Wittichová, UN CIMIC officers often carry out co-ordination and humanitarian activities:⁷² so was here the case.

Thus, collaborative instruments can be articulated with NGOs, or through small-scale aid projects to replace the lack of public policies, e.g., repairing infrastructure, or providing material resources in a wrecked state. Excellent examples include Quick Impact Projects (QIPs) as an essential component of CIMIC.⁷³ In the words of Jan Daniel, developing CIMIC knowledge and practice has entailed "introducing a number of small-scale sovereignty-building projects primarily aimed at strengthening the sovereign agency of the Lebanese state".⁷⁴

QIPs, in fact, were described by the UNIFIL Strategic Revision in 2012 'as an essential tool to maintain and enhance the engagement of the central authorities in southern Lebanon through their involvement in [sic] implementation of projects that address the basic needs of the local population in the area'.⁷⁵ QIPs are considered a key and visible tool to build reliability in the eyes of local populations,⁷⁶ while at the same time support local governance, replacing the public policies that the Lebanese state cannot provide in the UNIFIL's area of influence.

The Spanish military in Lebanon always distinguished between CIMIC work, with a long-term perspective, seeking local collaboration, etc., and the direct provision of humanitarian aid. In fact, QIPs were the main way for this type of actions, with almost always scarce, or no co-operation with NGOs. This is one of the identified reasons why the Spanish peacekeepers deployed had very little contact with this kind of (international) actor, with respect to whom certain misgivings were expressed by the

military in the interviews. Notwithstanding, QIPs are appreciated as a valid, effective instrument for reinforcing local legitimacy, which promoted the ownership of Lebanese authorities: '[Local authorities] try to get our help through QIPs and when they inaugurate that project, they do it in public and make it clear that it was thanks to their influence'.⁷⁷

The number of projects undertaken by the various forces vary considerably.⁷⁸ Spain has attached great importance to QIPs and other humanitarian activities: 53.8 per cent of the troops interviewed in 2015 answered that they had engaged in humanitarian assistance in Lebanon, such as direct support from UNIFIL battalions and social-cultural actions.⁷⁹ The projects in its sphere of influence have basically consisted of infrastructure and important engineering support projects related to the electrical grid, water infrastructure, agricultural and livestock development, and healthcare.⁸⁰ Richer countries like Spain, Italy, and France finance more QIPs than other countries with fewer resources, within UNIFIL budget and additionally on a bilateral basis.⁸¹ The Spanish battalion financed at least one extra project per town in its area of responsibility, works that were highly valued by the local communities, according to interviewees.

Between 2006 and 2016, Spain had a large budget marked for activities in its area of influence in the Lebanese administrative district of Marjayoun, where it funded projects that served 54 villages and towns and a total population of 99,000.⁸² During this period, it has been carried out a total of 645 QIPs.⁸³⁸⁴ Other types of social projects were also completed, including activities related to gender equality, children and women, as well as projects in the field of cultural relations involving teaching Spanish language to more than 5500 students in 10 years as part of the Instituto Cervantes programme.⁸⁵

The importance of having structures that meet these needs are essential to ensure that the mission's work is viewed in a positive light and to facilitate the completion of the mandate. At the same time, this helps to prevent threats, as the communities see this aid as improving their lives, producing a perception of the Lebanese state as more proximate. In fact, the material actions performed by a mission can provide the benefits that could be offered by players other than the state. All the military personnel interviewed who were involved in the development of CIMIC tasks agreed on its positive impact on building closeness, trust, etc., this being the main outcome beyond the particular outputs of each QIPs.

Non-materials actions: the importance of interactions, culture of discourses

Legitimacy needs to be constructed in a way that is consistent with local values.⁸⁶ Communities, in general, must feel that their local customs are not threatened and that the protocols are respected. In particular, Muslim communities must perceive respect for their Islamic values.⁸⁷ This was partly an obstacle—at least in the initial stages—to the work of the peacekeepers, who recognised more friction with the local Muslim populations than with the Christian ones: “depending on the area and the personnel involved, the treatment received differs between an area with a majority Christian population, and other areas where the relationship is more complicated because they are Muslims, and the contrast with religion is a barrier”.⁸⁸ This difference was reflected in the attitude of local elites: “always within institutional respect, it ranged from forced indifference, like Shiite authorities in the village of El Khiam, to unconditional support in the villages of the 'Christian corridor' close to the Spanish military base 'Miguel de Cervantes’”.⁸⁹

To that end, the control and development of certain narratives is very important. The UNIFIL narrative aligns the mission's needs with the interest, power and authority of the local communities by emphasising a common interest in stability and local economic development. UNIFIL II, specifically, has greatly improved public communication to reach local audiences as well as local links, by resolving incidents with the leaders of the communities concerned. Notably, UNIFIL presents a discourse that combines aspects of peacebuilding in civil society and peace discourses, emphasising the cosmopolitan ethos of the mission and the values it represents.⁹⁰

On the other hand, as discussed in greater detail above, the discourse adopted by subnational elites, especially the leaders of the Shiite community in this scenario, may use religious discourses to achieve their objectives of threatening the peaceful state of affairs and weaponising the situation to obtain what they want. Peacekeeper discourses, instead, are pragmatic, and the mentality behind them is much more rational than 'mythical'. Accordingly, it is essential for military personnel to be able to distinguish between mythical and rational narratives.

In this respect, the respondents stressed during the fieldwork that, although the relationship with the peacekeepers was good, those differences aroused: "being a Muslim area, the population was always more reluctant to socialise".⁹¹ However, in general, there was a sufficient degree of trust and respect, as commented in the two focus groups. Locals saw security as a common issue for everyone, even if that was not the case very early on: "I think [the various Lebanese authorities and the local population] were a bit suspicious, having been a war-zone where law and order had not existed for a period of time";⁹² "the multinational brigade gave them development, stability and therefore peace".⁹³

In consequence, adequate relationships are useful in terms of obtaining the tools to improve state legitimacy, because the mission officials' performance had to be perceived as good governance as implemented by the state. For these reasons, fostering non-material or ideational actions is related to respecting local ways of life.⁹⁴ If the military culture of the national contingent fosters a better relationship with the local communities, it will be easier to promote a positive perception.⁹⁵ Therefore, one interviewee stated: "cross-cultural awareness must also be promoted among the civilian population and with the civilian population".⁹⁶ In this sense, the language of the operations and the actions used have changed progressively, and humanitarian actions – working on behalf of human rights, good governance, and so forth, were considered standard army activities.

In the case study presented here, almost all the military respondents had had some kind of relationship with three groups: (i) the subnational elites, (ii) the population, (iii) and the LAF, regardless of whether or not they were part of CIMIC teams. Additionally, most of the military and local actors interviewed rated the relationships as being generally positive. Regarding the subnational elites, 47.4 per cent of the respondents said that their relationship with the local authorities had been enriching, because they had the opportunity to interact with people from other cultures.⁹⁷ Only some respondents reported that the subnational elites had tried to bypass the Lebanese civil and military authorities, using their relationship with the international peacekeepers to obtain benefits.

The explanation for this data lies in two factors. On the one hand, because of the number of years that UNIFIL has been deployed, it has been possible to form strong connections with both the Lebanese forces and local populations.⁹⁸ On the other hand, as Spain has been one of the main contributors to the implementation of QIPs, it has

established itself as one of the most authoritative countries in its relationships with the local population.⁹⁹ This is reflected in the words of some of the Spanish interviewees too: one officer noted that, “in Lebanon, we had a very good relationship with the local authorities. We had a very positive attitude, but theirs was even more positive. Their attitude was very good in every way, whether by necessity or as a cultural aspect or for whatever reason”.¹⁰⁰ In the words of another, “yes, with mayors, police chiefs, etc. [we have always had an] appropriate relationship, provided that the same conditions were maintained as with the local population: respect and courtesy”.¹⁰¹

The perception on the part of the local authorities parallels these opinions, reflecting a belief that UNIFIL and the Spanish military are sensitive to the protocols, norms and values of local populations, which also produces greater peace of mind.¹⁰² Some locals even expressed that they have a certain cultural proximity to the Spaniards, based on their physical features.¹⁰³ This is an interesting detail, since this perceived closeness balances the misgivings defined by the different religious backgrounds. Indeed, geographical proximity, or sharing certain cultural characteristics has been shown to increase trust between international and local actors and; consequently, in facilitating peacebuilding operations. Whilst the ‘real’ social and cultural distance between Spanish peacekeepers and Lebanese society might be large, the efforts to develop greater intercultural awareness towards the civilian population contributed to reducing the ‘perceived’ distance.

It should be noted that 100 per cent of the troops interviewed who took part in UNIFIL in 2015 had some type of contact with the locals. The relationship with the Lebanese population, the focal point of the Spanish military tasks, was described as positive in most of the interviews. Some members of the army who were interviewed valued their relationships this way because they were close and friendly, reflecting the

impact of non-material interactions. Hence, in addition to their military abilities, personal skills and even cultural proximity was important. The Spanish military sought an explicit empathic social engagement with the local population to reduce the potential gap in cultural, or social values. All of the respondents interacted with the local population in some way. Except for the members of the CIMIC teams, 53.8 per cent of the respondents participated in some form of ancillary task or humanitarian aid.¹⁰⁴

This dynamic of work constitutes a more ‘people-centric’ peacebuilding operation, in terms of Cedric de Coning et al.:¹⁰⁵ within an institutional framework established by the host nation and the international organisation, facilitates the mutual understanding between the ‘Blue Helmets’ and the local population; according to the responses of the local interviewees, the Lebanese population valued both as recipient of services via QIPs and as an agent of change itself.

Relations with the LAF consisted of co-ordination on the ground, regular attendance at joint security and status meetings, and the above-mentioned joint patrols. The assessment of contacts with the Lebanese military by the Spanish peacekeepers was equally positive, which is most likely due to the acceptance that the LAF has among the local population; indeed, according to Newby, “local populations support the objectives of LAF and UNIFIL, in relations to LAF’s future role”.¹⁰⁶ However, that study uncovered some interesting findings: for instance, the first European contingents had to undergo an adaptation process related to initial frictions with the local populations¹⁰⁷ but, since this was clearly a standard mission, the problem was easy to solve; secondly, although the overall assessments were positive, at times various respondents harboured some suspicions about the real commitment of these local actors to the mission's objectives.

These elements encounter two of the criticism stated by Paffenholz about ‘romanticising’ the local actor in peacebuilding contexts, as well as the neglect of existing power relations in the society where the operation takes place.¹⁰⁸ In the case of UNIFIL, field practice shows local actors pursue their own interests and power strategies. Peacekeepers have to deal with this circumstance which, while it may be an initial obstacle, in the long run allows for a boost in local legitimacy and ownership.

The continued co-operation had a twofold effect: on the one hand, it increased confidence among the staff on the joint missions, while the communities involved also recognised the support and collaboration between the mission personnel and the LAF, based on the majority of responses from both types of actors involved; specifically, 92.3 per cent of the Spanish UNIFIL staff interviewed had a relationship with some members of the LAF and 74.6 per cent of the interviewees viewed these relationships positively. On the other, this circumstance facilitated the Spanish understanding of the local actors, increased contacts and built trusting relationships. The consequences of empathy in the relationships between international forces and the experience resulting from years of contact in Lebanon must be taken into account.¹⁰⁹

Even though these relationships are discontinuous for the military due to rotations, the institutional memory remains for the subnational elites, thanks to the work done by CIMIC contingencies and efforts to prepare similar procedures for the future. The CIMIC groups do not only provide public goods, but also give officers a place to develop test, and rehearse new sets of soft ‘non-military’ skills and learn how to handle relationships with civilians as military officers. The tasks carried out by CIMIC groups are associated with values such as empathy, communication, dialogue, and compassion.¹¹⁰ Therefore, refining positive relationships with local communities opens channels that promote an atmosphere of cordiality and trust that favours the

peacekeepers' roles as regulators. This behaviour, then, benefits the balance in favour of state institutions, providing the state with more resources to gain legitimacy.

Conclusion

This article presents a study that helps to fill a gap in the work done on how peacekeeping missions can support host states to gain local legitimacy from bottom-up approaches within their territories, tracking local practices, by establishing a connection between the provision of public goods and the strengthening of that legitimacy. The particular focus on UNIFIL II Spanish military contingent case study has shown how the peacekeepers' material actions, ancillary tasks, as well as their non-material actions; respect for the local culture and an in-depth understanding of the context that makes it possible to control the discourse of local actors, are key tools for these purposes, what could be extrapolate to other cases.

The article explains how UNIFIL II through the material and non-material actions could support the legitimacy of the state, creating an appropriate balance with subnational elites, and improving local ownership. Providing public services to local communities while respecting their cultures and leaders constitute support services for the host nation with a concomitant positive effect. Furthermore, Lebanon represents a challenging crisis in this respect, with various political and religious cleavages. In this sense, this research sheds light on how the acceptance of the international mission by local communities, with their own interests and strategies, becomes a vital goal.

In the Spanish case studied here, the role of the relationship maintained with the subnational elites was essential for the UNIFIL II actions to be effective. The primary objective of the mission, after all, is to ensure that these subnational elites, the key decision-makers on behalf of their communities, feel a connection to the Lebanese state

based on trust. The study identifies the importance of these transactions to empower the Lebanese state. Specifically, both the patrols and the QIPs implemented over the years increased the sense of trust felt by the Spanish peacekeepers, and so it is also stated by local leaders.

Notwithstanding, more than the high number of such actions, their importance lies in the outcomes achieved, aligned with the instrumental mission objective of enhancing the legitimacy and ownership of the host-nation at the sub-state level; at the same time, building trust through cross-cultural awareness was one of the key concepts observed in the interviews. Legitimacy was gained through these material achievements, and so is perceived by the military. In this regard, this research highlights the particular focus of Spain, one of the main contributors to UNIFIL II.

In conclusion, the peacekeepers' abilities to understand the local culture have become more fine-tuned, contributing to stronger cooperation, greater levels of trust, the creation of networks and some coincidence of preferences. The interviews reflected both the positive relationship with the local armed forces, the LAF, authorities and people, and the appreciation of this work on the part of these local communities. The qualitative outcome of ancillary tasks, in addition to closer relationships, improves the success rate of conflict resolution. The mission cannot carry out this task independently, but must include support for the host state among its undertakings in order to avoid creating a competition for legitimacy. On the contrary, all actions must be aimed at bolstering the construction of the host state with the backing of the local elites.

Comprehending the context and discourses of subnational elites is essential too, and this understanding must be factored into the strategic dimension of the mission. Additionally, mechanisms should be established to safeguard this knowledge at the tactical level. Further qualitative, or comparative research could therefore be oriented

towards the results of the combination of both types of actions in stabilisation, peacekeeping and state-building international missions, addressing new fields of research about the ‘local turn’,¹¹ or enriching lessons learned processes of past (e.g., MINUSMA), present (UNIFIL II itself, MINUSCA) and future (Haiti) UN operations.

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